



BISWARANJAN ROUT

favourite Kishore Jena, who booked his spot for Olympics with his silver medal-winning performance at the Hangzhou Asian Games, finished fifth with 75.49m. Jena opened his season along with Neeraj in Doha but there too, he could only produce 76.31m.

For many Olympic aspirants, the domestic outdoor season began with individual meets for 400m, jumps, and throws in March, followed by select events at the Indian Grand Prix-I on April 30.

Come the Federation Cup, the athletes were expected to at least get closer to the entry standards for Paris. And the strategy was to follow it up by gaining confidence through some overseas exposure before hitting one's stride at the National

Inter-State Championships from June 27 to 30 in Panchkula.

The conditions leading up to the competition were not ideal — the maximum temperature was hovering around 40 degrees and the humidity was considerably high. **But the heavy downpour on the night before the opening day made things much better.**

The 400m hurdlers were in focus on day one. T. Santhosh Kumar (above; centre), who finished sixth at the Asian Games and has a Personal Best (PB) of 49.09s, clinched gold but clocked 50.04s. R. Vithya Ramraj, the joint National Record-holder with the legendary P. T. Usha at 55.42s, pulled out at the start of the women's final with a back issue and Punjab's



K. R. DEEPAK



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PODCAST

Nayana James (right) defeated Shaili Singh for the top spot in women's long jump. But both were well short of the 6.86 mark for Paris.